# Clean, Cleaner, Cleanest

## By Sherman Alexie

**MARIE:** **(Pgs 45-54)** *(knocking)* Housekeeping. *(louder)* Housekeeping.

**NARRATOR:** On a Tuesday morning Marie knocked on the door of Room 213. A corner room. Larger than standard. With two big windows instead of one. Twenty dollars more a night. The guest had been there for a few nights and was supposed to check out by eleven. *(Marie knocks again)* There was no response. *(Marie pushes it open, takes a step back)* That was a learned self-defense behavior. You didn't enter the room until you had a clear idea of what was waiting for you.

**MARIE:** Housekeeping.

## INTRODUCTION

*Hotel cleaning staff, predominantly women of color and immigrants, continue to face profound inequities in the hospitality industry. Despite their crucial role in maintaining cleanliness and ensuring guest safety, they rarely earn more than minimum wage, or have access to health insurance, sick leave, or job security. Many endure physically taxing and hazardous working conditions. These workers remain largely invisible, seldom*

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*acknowledged or valued by their employers or the guests they serve.*

*Marie's been doing this job for decades. This is her story, well . . . the **end** of her story and what she has seen may shock you.*

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**NARRATOR:** There was nobody in the living area. But the bathroom door was shut, so there could be somebody in there. A few years earlier, a naked guest had walked out of the bathroom as she was making the bed. They'd both yelped in surprise. Marie couldn't stop laughing as she fled the room. But her fear of used hypodermics had lessened over the years. She got needle-stuck once when she was pulling off a pillowcase. She rarely saw a needle after crack and meth became more popular and cheaper than any other drug. You could shoot up meth, but it seemed that most people snorted it. Or smoked it. And accidentally started fires in small motel rooms. But the needles were starting to reappear. She felt sorry for those addicts -- for any addicts. They ended up looking like starving ravens. Like scarecrows after a brush fire. Like

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the babies born when starved ravens conceived with burned scarecrows.

Seven people had died at the motel. Two from overdoses, four from heart attacks, and one when a woman drunkenly fell over the second-floor railing and landed headfirst on somebody else's minivan.

But she needed her job. She believed in her job. So, she cleaned the room. First, she picked up the dirty towels and shoved them into the laundry bag. She draped clean towels over the thin metal rod. The towels had been washed, yes, but they were so old that they'd forgotten how to be towels. And that thin metal rod had been pulled out of the wall so often by clumsy guests that it barely supported the weight of the towels. But no matter -- she still draped the towels with an eye-pleasing symmetry. Then she sprayed minty soap into the sink and the shower, did a quick wipe, and ran hot water to wash the soap down the drain. She knew she'd only cleaned the surface of things, but the soap's strong minty smell would make it seem as if she'd cleaned more thoroughly.

**MARIE:** *The illusion of clean.*

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**NARRATOR:** She'd once used that phrase when she'd been talking to Father James about her job, and he'd said that the phrase accurately described humans as well.

It took her only fifteen minutes to clean that room. That was good, because a mother and father with four kids had checked out of Room 144. The youngest kid, a toddler in a polo shirt, had taken off his pants and underwear -- had gone full Porky Pig -- then squatted and pushed out a public feces in front of the soda machine.

After so many years, Marie didn't even mind cleaning up people's feces and urine. She had discovered that it was vital to say "feces" and "urine" instead of using cruder terms for the messes that people left in the toilet. Or ***on*** the toilet. Or in the general vicinity of the toilet. Or sometimes not even in the bathroom at all. "Feces" and "urine" were medical terms. She was a motel maid, but it helped to think like a doctor or a nurse. It helped to think that she was ***helping*** people.

Marie was deathly afraid of what that family might have done in the privacy of their room. She dreaded the marathon of cleaning that likely awaited her. *(beat)*

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In the beginning, there was Marie, Agnes, Rosa, and the other Rosa. Agnes was a drunk. She got fired for stealing from the guests. Rosa No. 1 married her high-school sweetheart and moved away; Rosa No. 2 was undocumented and quit after she heard rumors about an immigration sweep of local businesses. The sweep didn't happen. Not that time.

Over the years, thirty or forty women had quit without saying a word. Many of them never bothered to pick up their last paychecks. Marie feared that some of those women might have been ***disappeared*** by the men in their lives. But most of them just didn't care. Over the decades, Marie had worked with two or three hundred women.

There were drug addicts and alcoholics and women who dowsed their cleaning rags with disinfectant and huffed those poisonous fumes into their lungs. There were illegal and legal immigrants, though Marie didn't care about their status. Every refugee is a precious child, she thought. There were maids of every race. Of every color. Of every religion.

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There were women who cried often but would never explain their tears. There were women who never stopped talking about their aches and pains.

Marie's knees and ankles hurt because she had so often squatted and kneeled to clean the floors. Her feet hurt because she stood for most of the day. And she'd never owned a good pair of work shoes.

One day, she'd twisted her back so severely that she'd collapsed in pain on the sidewalk. At the free clinic, she learned that "back spasms" was the fancy way to say "torn muscles." Once or twice a year since then, she'd torn her back again. But she'd missed only a few days of work. She'd spend one day in bed, recovering, and then she'd force herself back to cleaning.

She'd slowly gained weight, three or four pounds a year. Not much, until you add it all up and discover that you're a two-hundred-pound woman. The extra weight didn't help her back. She went on dozens of diets. She failed.

Her hands hurt. Arthritis. And the recurring rashes caused by the soaps and disinfectants. Her skin itched and burned. She tried wearing gloves at work, but that only

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made her rashes migrate from her hands to her wrists, forearms, and elbows.

Some mornings, she woke with hands so stiff that she could not make fists. She could not hold her coffee cup or toothbrush. She'd submerge her hands in hot water and flex and flex until her fingers worked properly again.

**MARIE:** It's hard work. But it's not like working in a coal mine . . . Everything is temporary.

**NARRATOR:** On her last day of work, at age sixty-three, Marie was given a peculiar honor.

**OWNER:** You only have to clean one room.

**MARIE:** But I ***want*** the last full shift.

**NARRATOR:** Why? Because she needed that sense of completion. Because she wanted to use that last bit of money to buy herself a retirement gift. A new watch, perhaps, now that she didn't have to worry about ruining it with water or cleaning fluids.

**OWNER:** I'll pay you full shift for cleaning one room. That is my gift to you.

**NARRATOR:** So, she took her time. She scrubbed the toilet, sink, and shower with bleach. She picked wildflowers from a sidewalk crack, placed them in a plastic cup and

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set that on the bathroom windowsill. Then she polished all the wooden furniture. It was too cheap and old and battered to sparkle. But a dim star is more visible than a dark star. She cleaned the windows. That took a long time, because the windows had rarely been cleaned. This was the kind of motel where the curtains were rarely opened.

Finally, after three hours of cleaning Marie stepped out of the room and locked the door behind her.

The owner gave Marie her last paycheck in cash. Two weeks' worth of money. Six hundred dollars. With Social Security and Medicaid and Medicare and good luck, Marie and her husband would survive.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

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## AWARD HISTORY

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